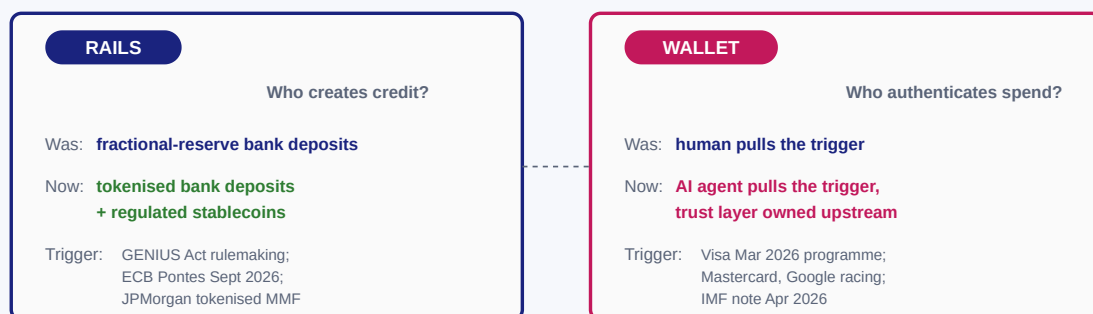


Money rewires the rails. Now agents rewire the wallet.

Two weeks ago, the May Decision Intelligence briefing made a confident case: the settlement layer is being rebuilt around tokenised money, and treasury and payments leaders should pick which rail to standardise on. Three deliverables later, the cycle has sharpened that thesis on two distinct surfaces. The rails surface is consolidating faster than the briefing assumed (stablecoin rulemaking, tokenised bank deposits, wholesale settlement going live). And a second surface has appeared: payment networks and protocol owners are now racing to own the agent authentication layer, because in the agentic-commerce era liability follows authentication. Read as a single body of work, the four pieces surface three patterns no individual deliverable carries on its own.

TWO SURFACES BEING REWIRED



Two surfaces. Both being rewired. Liability follows authentication on the right; deposit franchise follows tokenisation on the left.

The two surfaces the cycle's four deliverables surfaced. The rails surface is rebuilt by tokenised bank money and post-GENIUS stablecoins; the wallet surface is rebuilt by the agent authentication race that the 1 June Signal Scan caught early.

DRAWING ON

- Decision Intelligence, 19 May 2026 · 'Money Rewires Itself: Rails, Reserves and Rulebooks'
- Change Tracker, 21 May 2026 · 'Stablecoin rules harden as tokenised bank money scales and cash plateaus'

- Signal Scan, 25 May 2026 · 'The Narrow-Banking Drift: how stablecoins are quietly reshaping who creates credit'

- Signal Scan, 1 June 2026 · 'Know Your Agent: how the race to authenticate AI buyers is rewiring payment liability'

Early warnings

Four developments the portfolio caught before consensus formed, in the order they hardened.

SPEED OF CONSENSUS CATCH-UP: ~7 WEEKS

DI BRIEF

SIGNAL SCAN, 25 MAY

Stablecoins do not just substitute deposits; they displace fractional-reserve credit creation

The May briefing positioned stablecoins as a deposit-substitution story inside the "\$6 trillion war for deposits". The 25 May Signal Scan went further: stablecoins are converting credit-creating fractional-reserve bank deposits into fully-reserved narrow-bank substitutes, which changes who creates credit in the economy, not just where deposits sit. Consensus has not yet caught up to this implication. The macro and prudential question (what happens to credit supply if a meaningful share of deposits migrates to narrow-bank stablecoin-issuer balance sheets) is the next sit-up for central banks and bank supervisors.

SPEED OF CONSENSUS CATCH-UP: ~2 WEEKS

SIGNAL SCAN, 1 JUNE

Payment networks are already racing for the agent authentication trust layer

The 1 June Signal Scan surfaced that Visa's March 2026 agent-payments programme, parallel work at Mastercard, and an IMF note in April 2026 have moved the agent authentication question from research to commercial race in three months. Liability follows authentication; whoever owns the agent trust layer owns the rules that govern when a bank, network or wallet is on the hook for a fraudulent or in-error agent transaction. Consensus framing still treats agentic commerce as a consumer-convenience story; the cycle's evidence says it is a network-economics story.

STABLE CENTRE OF GRAVITY

CHANGE TRACKER

The cash plateau is now a structural backstop, not a fading category

The 21 May Change Tracker classified the cashless transition as Fading, anchored on the Fed Diary of Consumer Payment Choice showing cash as the third payment method for the sixth consecutive year. Cash will not collapse on the timetable the May DI implicitly assumed; payment-rail evolution must operate alongside a persistent cash backstop. The implication for resilience planning (what happens to the digital rails if a major outage hits) shifts from theoretical to operational.

Wholesale tokenised settlement goes live before the retail digital euro lands

The ECB Pontes wholesale settlement service goes live September 2026; the Appia roadmap was published March 2026. The retail digital euro is still pre-legislation and on a multi-year build with no inflection this cycle. The sequence (wholesale first, retail later) means corporate treasury and interbank flows will tokenise materially before the consumer-facing CBDC question is resolved, with implications for which rail standards lock in first.

Assumptions that are shifting

Four explicit shifts between the 19 May briefing and the body of work that followed, in decreasing order of strategic weight.

SHIFT 1 OF 4

"Money is being rewired on the rails"

The May briefing framing was a single-surface story. The cycle's body of work splits it in two. **Rails surface** (tokenised bank deposits, regulated stablecoins, wholesale settlement) is the May framing reinforced. **Wallet surface** (who or what authenticates spend) is a second, distinct rewire that the 1 June scan introduced. Single-surface investment plans will under-cover one of the two.

SHIFT 2 OF 4

"Stablecoins are a deposit substitution question"

Held by the May briefing as part of the deposit-franchise contest. The 25 May Signal Scan reframes it: stablecoins are a credit-creation displacement question because the issuer reserve structure (full reserves backing) does not create credit the way fractional-reserve bank deposits do. The macro and prudential implication is materially larger than the deposit-franchise framing.

SHIFT 3 OF 4

"AI agents will simply shop for consumers"

Implicit in the May briefing's payment-rails framing. Refuted by the 1 June scan. Payment networks have moved before the consensus framing did, and the agent authentication question is now a commercial race for trust-layer ownership with concrete first-mover positions (Visa programme March 2026).

SHIFT 4 OF 4

"Cash will fade as digital rails scale"

Implicit in the May briefing's settlement-layer-rebuild framing. The Tracker classified cash transition as Fading and named the Fed Diary six-year evidence base. Cash is not fading on a usefully near-term timeline; resilience planning and rail-design assumptions need to reflect a persistent cash backstop.

Actions triggered

Decisions now decision-shaped enough to act on, with Decide / Prepare / Monitor postures and named owners.

DECIDE

ACTION 1

DI BRIEF

CHANGE TRACKER

Treasury and payments leaders standardise on a primary tokenised-money rail before the GENIUS Act 120-day clock expires

Group Treasurers and Heads of Payments at corporates and at banks should commit to a primary tokenised-money rail (regulated stablecoin issuer + tokenised bank deposit programme) before the OCC final rule starts the GENIUS Act 120-day effective-date clock. The Tracker named that comment-window close in June 2026; the implementation runway is short, and reference-pricing dynamics propagate first-mover choices through customer flows.

PREPARE

ACTION 2

SIGNAL SCAN, 1 JUNE

Banks and PSPs stand up agent authentication trust-layer integration ahead of payment-network lock-in

Banks, payment service providers and large merchants should authorise a 12-month workstream to integrate with the emerging agent authentication trust layer (Visa, Mastercard, Google), before any single network's standard locks in. Liability follows authentication, and the contractual position of an institution that signs into a third-party trust layer at the end of the lock-in window is materially worse than one that signs in early. The Prepare posture reflects that no single standard is yet binding.

PREPARE

ACTION 3

SIGNAL SCAN, 25 MAY

Central banks and prudential supervisors model the credit-creation impact of stablecoin scaling

Central banks (Fed, ECB, BoE) and prudential supervisors should commission an explicit model of the credit-creation impact if a meaningful share of M2 migrates from fractional-reserve bank deposits to fully-reserved stablecoin balances. The 25 May Signal Scan's reframing makes this question materially more pressing than a deposit-franchise framing implied. The Prepare posture reflects that the modelling work is a 12-18 month research programme.

Watch the September 2026 ECB Pontes go-live and the European Parliament digital euro vote as the wholesale-versus-retail sequencing trigger

Operators across the European payments stack should track two named cycle 3 milestones: the September 2026 ECB Pontes wholesale settlement service go-live, and the European Parliament vote on the digital euro regulation. The escalation trigger from Monitor to Prepare is either milestone landing materially ahead of or behind schedule; the sequence (wholesale before retail) determines which rail standards lock in first and which corporate treasury choices are reversible.

The body of work, in one sentence

The May briefing's single-surface tokenisation thesis has resolved into a two-surface architectural question: **which tokenised-money rail to standardise on, and how to authenticate the agent or human pulling the trigger**; single-surface investment plans will under-cover one of the two.

This Action Triggers is the end-of-cycle synthesis of a Shaping Tomorrow intelligence cycle on **Financial Services and the Future of Money**. It reads across the cycle's weekly Signal Scans, monthly Change Trackers and quarterly Decision Intelligence briefing, and surfaces the patterns no single deliverable carries on its own: the early warnings the work caught before consensus formed, the assumptions that have shifted between cycles, and the actions now decision-shaped enough to act on. Continuous intelligence on this topic is available as a Single-Topic or Multi-Topic programme.